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Healing Himalayas
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VILLAGE
A CASE STUDY AROUND COMMUNITY-LEVEL ZERO WASTE MANAGEMENT INITIATIVE
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CONTEXT & PROBLEM STATEMENT

- Despite existing collection systems, households continued generating mixed waste at source, reducing recycling efficiency.
- Poor segregation increased risk of injury to sanitation workers handling glass and contaminated waste.
- Studies indicate that behavioural resistance is a primary barrier in urban waste compliance (Ajzen, 1991).
- Weak enforcement structures diluted accountability within the system.

OBJECTIVES

1

Identify behavioural and operational barriers in 160+ surveyed households.

2

Support RWA and sanitation workers in strengthening source-level enforcement.

3

Generate data-backed recommendations for decentralized waste system improvement.

4

Align field intervention with:

- SDG 8: Safer and dignified sanitation work.
- SDG 9: Community-level infrastructure strengthening.

Conducted block-wise monitoring across 350+ households over 3 intensive tracking days.

Surveyed 160+ households to assess awareness and compliance levels.

Conducted 8 stakeholder interviews (RWA officials, sanitation workers, NGO staff, residents).

Used daily reflection meetings to validate field observations.

Mixed-method field studies improve contextual validity in community research (Yin, 2018).

METHODOLOGY

KEY FINDINGS (DATA-BACKED)

Initial monitoring indicated recurring non-compliance across specific blocks.

Worker-led refusal of mixed waste contributed to approximately 20% improvement in segregation compliance.

Awareness-only communication had limited impact unless supported by enforcement.

Workers reported reduced workload strain when segregation improved.

Behaviour change was stronger in blocks with consistent monitoring.

Behavioural reinforcement combined with institutional backing improves compliance outcomes (Thaler & Sunstein, 2008).

IMPACT & SDG ALIGNMENT

Observed Impact:

- Noticeable reduction in mixed waste cases within monitored blocks.
- Improved confidence and authority among sanitation workers.
- RWA adopted structured monitoring discussions based on field data.

SDG 8 – Decent Work

- Reduced risk exposure from improperly segregated hazardous waste.
- Strengthened worker dignity through institutional backing.

SDG 9 – Infrastructure

- Enhanced decentralized waste processes at community level.
- Introduced data-informed governance mechanisms.

INTELLECTUAL OUTCOME

CASE STUDY

This project evolves into a Case Study because:

- It captures real-time system dynamics across multiple stakeholders.
- It documents governance, behavioural, and operational interactions.
- It presents replicable insights for urban residential waste systems.

Case studies are appropriate where context-specific process understanding is central (Yin, 2018).

CONCLUSION & WAY FORWARD

- **Sustainable segregation requires behavioural reinforcement, not awareness alone.**
- Worker empowerment is central to decentralized waste governance.
- Institutional continuity is necessary to prevent compliance relapse.
- The model can inform similar RWAs across Delhi seeking SDG-aligned urban sustainability transitions.

APA 7th EDITION REFERENCES

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